

Public Companies: Space & Space Exploration

Launch providers plus the technology and payload companies that benefit from riding to orbit

Context: SpaceX went public on Nasdaq (SPCX) in mid-June 2026 in the largest IPO in history, pricing at \$135/share and closing its first day up 19% at roughly a \$2 trillion valuation. This gave the entire sector a public valuation anchor for the first time in two decades. The immediate effect was a sharp, synchronized rally across nearly every listed space name -- followed by an equally sharp "SpaceX Effect" pullback in late June as investors rotated capital into the newly listed giant. The global space economy is projected to grow from ~\$630B today to \$1.8 trillion by 2035.

1. Launch Providers

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
SpaceX	SPCX	Dominant global launch provider (Falcon 9, Starship) and owner of the Starlink broadband constellation	IPO'd mid-June 2026 at ~\$2T valuation, the largest IPO ever; Starlink has 12M+ subscribers generating ~\$11B annual revenue; Falcon 9 captured ~84% of US launches in 2024
Rocket Lab	RKLB	World's #3 launch provider behind SpaceX and China's CASC; Electron rocket plus growing Space Systems (satellite parts/manufacturing) business	Q1 2026 record revenue \$200.3M (+63% YoY), backlog \$2.2B; \$8B pending acquisition of Iridium; Neutron medium-lift rocket targeting Q4 2026 first flight after a tank-failure delay
Firefly Aerospace	FLY	Small-lift Alpha rocket plus Blue Ghost lunar lander heritage and growing spacecraft-solutions business	Listed on Nasdaq in 2025; record Q1 2026 revenue ~\$80.9M (+45% YoY); NASA selected its Elytra spacecraft for the Moonfall lunar drone-delivery mission

2. Satellite Manufacturers & Operators

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
MDA Space	TSX: MDA	Canadian satellite manufacturer and space-robotics company; builds AURORA software-defined satellites and the Canadarm robotic arms	Building next-gen constellations for Globalstar and Telesat Lightspeed; co-venture partner in the Starlab commercial space station
Iridium Communications	IRDM	Operates a 66-satellite LEO constellation for global voice/data communications	Subject of Rocket Lab's pending \$8B acquisition, which would vertically integrate launch with satellite communications
Globalstar	GSAT	LEO satellite network for voice, data, and IoT; supplies the satellite link behind Apple's Emergency SOS feature	Apple holds ~20% stake; Amazon announced an agreement to acquire Globalstar in April 2026, subject to closing conditions

3. Satellite Communications & Connectivity

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
AST SpaceMobile	ASTS	Building a LEO network connecting directly to ordinary, unmodified smartphones via large phased-array BlueBird satellites	Partnerships with ~60 mobile operators including AT&T, Verizon, Vodafone; Q1 2026 committed contract revenue over \$1.2B; analysts project 140% 2026 revenue growth accelerating to 340% in 2027

Viasat	VSAT	High-capacity geostationary satellite communications: broadband, in-flight connectivity, government/military comms	2023 Inmarsat acquisition continues to add L-band mobile-satellite service scale
EchoStar	Ticker changing SATS to ECHO	Satellite/wireless services via Hughes, Boost Mobile, DISH TV, Sling	Sold spectrum blocks to AT&T and SpaceX (partly for SpaceX stock) in 2025, giving indirect SpaceX exposure; planned Starlink Direct to Cell link for Boost Mobile

4. Earth Observation & Imagery

Companies whose entire business is technology that only works once launched -- imaging satellites sold as a data/analytics subscription.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Planet Labs	PL	Largest Earth-observation fleet (Dove, Pelican, SkySat); imagery/analytics sold to agriculture, government, mapping, defense customers	~\$13B market cap; shares hit 52-week highs near \$38; fiscal 2026 losses widened to \$247M as it continues to scale
BlackSky	BKSY	AI-enhanced very-high-resolution satellite imagery (down to 35cm), on track to become the largest such constellation by end of 2026	Smaller than Planet at ~\$1.3B market cap but resolution-differentiated
Spire Global	SPIR	"Space-as-a-Service": leases satellite capacity and hosts custom third-party payloads on its satellite bus	Recurring-revenue model distinct from pure imagery sales; named a Stifel Buy alongside SpaceX and Rocket Lab
Satellogic	SATL	Earth observation imagery and analytics provider	Smaller-cap peer to Planet Labs and BlackSky in the imagery/analytics space

5. Space Infrastructure, Components & In-Space Manufacturing

This is the category most directly matching what you described: companies whose technology is delivered on/with rockets and satellites built by others -- the 'picks and shovels' of the orbital economy.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Redwire	RDW	Space infrastructure conglomerate: solar arrays, sensors, avionics, deployable structures, and the only commercial 3D printing facility on the ISS	2025 revenue \$335M (+10%); Q1 2026 revenue up as much as 70% YoY on Edge Autonomy drone acquisition; prime contractor on DARPA Otter program; supplies inflatable habitats for Starlab and other ISS-successor stations
Karman Holdings	KRMN	Payload-protection, propulsion, and interstage hardware for missile-defense, hypersonics, and space-launch programs	Strong revenue growth as defense/hypersonic demand accelerates; named a Stifel Buy alongside SpaceX and Rocket Lab
Mercury Systems	MRCY	Defense electronics for space and aerospace payloads	Core electronics supplier across the defense/space payload overlap

Note: Redwire's in-space manufacturing pipeline (pharmaceuticals, fiber optics, advanced materials made in microgravity) is the clearest example of the 'benefits from technology delivered by rocket' framing you described -- this is a distinct, longer-horizon revenue stream from its hardware-supply business.

6. Lunar & Deep Space Exploration

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Intuitive Machines	LUNR	Builds landers, robots, and infrastructure for lunar missions; NASA Commercial Lunar Payload Services contractor	Guided for \$900M-\$1B 2026 revenue (up from \$210M in 2025) and positive adjusted EBITDA; backlog ~\$943M; \$4.8B Near Space Network contract

7. Commercial Space Stations & Habitats

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Voyager Technologies	VOYG	Defense/national security, space solutions, and majority owner of the Starlab commercial space station JV (with Airbus, Mitsubishi, MDA Space, Palantir)	Listed on NYSE June 2025; closed upsized \$250M credit facility; acquiring lunar company Astrobotic (expected close July 2026)

Note: Axiom Space, the other leading ISS-successor developer, remains private.

8. Space Tourism

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Virgin Galactic	SPCE	Suborbital space tourism	The most cautionary space-SPAC story: down over 90% from its 2021 peak of \$12B+ market cap; paused commercial flights to develop lower-cost Delta-class spacecraft

9. Defense Primes with Major Space Segments

Large diversified contractors for whom space is one of several major businesses -- lower-beta space exposure with none of the pure-play volatility above.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Lockheed Martin	LMT	~\$13B annual space revenue: Orion spacecraft for Artemis, GPS III satellites, classified sensor programs	2024 Terran Orbital acquisition added smallsat manufacturing at scale; the ballast/low-risk way to hold space exposure
Northrop Grumman	NOC	Major space systems contractor across national security and NASA programs	Strategic partner named in the Starlab commercial space station venture
L3Harris Technologies	LHX	Space payloads, ground systems, and national security space programs	Continued space/defense payload integration work alongside its broader defense portfolio
RTX	RTX	Space sensors and defense systems overlapping with missile-defense/space-launch hardware	Broad defense/space payload exposure alongside its core aerospace business

10. Ground Equipment & Downstream Telecom Beneficiaries

Companies on the ground that directly benefit from expanding satellite constellations without launching anything themselves -- the clearest match for 'benefiting from technology delivered by rocket.'

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Wistron NeWeb	TWSE: 6285	LEO satellite ground reception terminals; dual-supplies both SpaceX and Amazon Kuiper	Record Q1 2026 revenue (NT\$29.16B) on doubling Starlink user base; annual revenue target NT\$125.5B

T-Mobile US	TMUS	Wireless carrier offering satellite-to-phone connectivity via Starlink Direct to Cell	Extends coverage to dead zones using standard phones and existing spectrum, starting with messaging
Verizon	VZ	Wireless/broadband carrier pursuing satellite connectivity via AST SpaceMobile partnership	Working toward direct-to-device service and rural broadband/backhaul via satellite partners
Kratos Defense	KTOS	Satellite ground systems alongside its drone/defense business (see Defense list)	Named a Stifel Buy across both its drone and space-adjacent ground systems exposure

Categories Worth Adding

- **Additive Manufacturing for Rocket Components** — Velo3D (VELO) makes metal 3D printers used to manufacture rocket engine parts; a distinct upstream manufacturing-technology layer named alongside Redwire and Rocket Lab in 2026 sector coverage.
- **Small/Micro-Cap Recent Listings** — Starfighters Space (FJET) just joined the Russell 3000 (June 2026); this space is producing new small-cap listings quickly enough that a screener should expect turnover here more than in your other lists.
- **Space-Adjacent ETFs** — ARKX, UFO, and the Procure Space ETF (WARP-tracking VanEck fund) offer diversified space exposure and are useful as a benchmark even though they're funds, not operating companies.
- **National Security/Intelligence Space** — Space Development Agency and Space Force contract flow (already touched via Rocket Lab and Redwire above) is arguably significant enough to warrant separating from 'defense primes' as its own category if you want to track government space spending specifically.

Generated July 10, 2026. This is a disjoint reference set, not a ranked or filtered list. Note: this sector saw an extremely sharp rally into the SpaceX IPO followed by a sharp "SpaceX Effect" pullback in late June 2026 as capital rotated into the new listing -- expect elevated volatility relative to your other lists.